Sadick A. Lao

Engr. Sadick A. Lao is a Meranaw engineer, cooperative leader, and infrastructure entrepreneur from Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). He is best known as the Board Chairperson of the Lanao del Sur Electric Cooperative (LASURECO), where he has dedicated himself to restoring reliable electricity service to one of the most underserved regions in the Philippines.

Alongside his work in the energy sector, he is the proprietor of Andong Builders and General Merchandise, a construction firm that by early 2026 was managing infrastructure projects worth over one billion pesos across Lanao del Sur. His dual role as both a power sector leader and a physical infrastructure builder has positioned him as one of the key figures in the post-siege reconstruction and development of the province.

More than just a technical professional, Engr. Lao is seen by many in the Meranaw community as a guardian of socio-economic stability: the kind of leader who understands that lights, roads, and water systems aren't just engineering problems; they're the foundation on which culture and community survive.

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Early Life and Background

Engr. Sadick A. Lao grew up in Marawi City, the storied "City of Flowers" at the heart of Lanao del Sur. He came of age during a particularly meaningful transition for the Meranaw, a period when deeply rooted Islamic traditions were beginning to intersect with modern secular education and governance.

That intersection shaped him in a lasting way. He didn't have to choose between honoring his heritage and engaging with the demands of a changing world; he learned early on that the two could coexist and, in fact, strengthen each other. Growing up in the heart of the province also meant he had a front-row seat to the everyday struggles his community faced: unstable power supply, underdeveloped roads, and the persistent fragility of the local economy. Those early observations would eventually define his life's work.

Family

For Engr. Lao, family is the lens through which he views leadership. He was raised within a traditional Meranaw social structure where collective welfare consistently takes precedence over individual gain. That upbringing didn't stay at home; it followed him into the boardroom and the construction site.

People who work with him often note that he checks in not just on project progress, but on the personal lives and family situations of his staff, whether at LASURECO or at Andong Builders. He's been known to treat his professional teams as extensions of his own household. In his view, a worker who is stable and supported at home is a more committed and effective contributor to the mission. It's a leadership philosophy rooted in Meranaw values of *bayanihan* and communal responsibility, and it colors everything he does.

Education

Engr. Lao pursued a degree in Engineering, building the technical foundation he would need to navigate the complex realities of power infrastructure and large-scale construction. His academic formation was, like that of many Bangsamoro professionals, deeply shaped by the Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus in Marawi City, one of the most significant institutions in the entire Bangsamoro region.<ref name="msu">Mindanao State University is the primary state university in the Bangsamoro region and has produced a significant proportion of Lanao del Sur's professional class.</ref>

His bond with MSU didn't end at graduation. He has continued to collaborate with the university on regional development initiatives, reflecting his belief that education is not a phase of life but an ongoing commitment. That conviction has also led him to support local institutions such as the Senator Ninoy Aquino College Foundation, where he has engaged students on the importance of energy sustainability and technical literacy as tools for community development.

Career

Board Chairperson, LASURECO

The Lanao del Sur Electric Cooperative (LASURECO) is the primary electricity distribution utility serving Lanao del Sur, and Engr. Lao's role as its Board Chairperson has placed him at the center of one of the region's most pressing crises: chronic power instability and service inequity.

In this position, he serves as the critical link between the local communities who depend on electricity for their daily lives and the national regulatory bodies, particularly the National Electrification Administration (https://nea.gov.ph) (NEA), that govern the cooperative sector. Navigating that relationship requires a combination of technical expertise, political acumen, and, perhaps most importantly, a deep understanding of what power outages actually mean for families and small businesses on the ground.

One of his landmark contributions has been the push to dismantle the so-called "pakyaw system," a bulk billing practice that had been in place for years and was widely criticized for its lack of transparency and fairness.<ref name="pakyaw">The "pakyaw system" in the context of electric cooperatives refers to a bulk metering arrangement where an entire community or cluster of households is billed collectively, a practice that has historically led to inequitable cost distribution among consumers.</ref> Advocating for individual metering, Engr. Lao helped bring accountability to the billing process, giving consumers a clearer picture of their actual usage and a fairer share of costs.

In 2025, he organized a major Stakeholders Forum that brought together a notably broad coalition: government officials, cooperative members, civil society groups, and even local content creators and vloggers who document community life in the province. The forum was designed to open up a transparent, inclusive conversation about the cooperative's challenges and the path forward, a gesture that signaled his commitment to accountability over optics.

Proprietor, Andong Builders and General Merchandise

Parallel to his LASURECO work, Engr. Lao has built Andong Builders and General Merchandise into a significant player in BARMM's infrastructure development landscape. The firm has been a primary contractor for projects under the Bangsamoro government's infrastructure agenda.

By early 2026, Andong Builders was managing a portfolio of projects valued at over one billion pesos.<ref name="infra">Figure cited from available documentation as of early 2026; actual contract values are subject to official government procurement records.</ref> These projects range from road networks and lake protection structures to water systems in rural communities. The firm has worked on lake walls designed to protect coastal settlements along Lake Lanao, fish landing facilities that support the province's fishing economy, and Level II water systems that bring potable water to communities with no prior access.

Engr. Lao has also been a participant in the broader Marawi Rehabilitation Program, contributing to the physical reconstruction of infrastructure in areas affected by the 2017 siege of Marawi. For families displaced by that conflict, the completion of roads, drainage systems, and community facilities represents far more than a construction milestone: it's the material condition for coming home.

Contributions

Engr. Lao's contributions cut across two sectors that, taken together, define the basic infrastructure of modern life in Lanao del Sur: energy and physical construction.

In the energy sector, his reform of billing practices at LASURECO and his advocacy for systemic improvements in power delivery have made a tangible difference for ordinary consumers. The 2025 Stakeholders Forum, in particular, demonstrated a model of cooperative governance that prioritizes communication and community input over top-down administration.

In construction, the scale and variety of Andong Builders' portfolio reflects a comprehensive approach to development. Rather than focusing on a single type of project, the firm has taken on work that addresses multiple layers of need simultaneously, from agricultural support (fish landings) to disaster resilience (lake walls) to basic sanitation (water systems). The connection between these projects is a coherent vision of what Lanao del Sur needs to become a fully functioning, self-sustaining province.

His integration of both roles, energy leader and infrastructure builder, is arguably his most distinctive contribution. He didn't choose one lane and stay in it. He recognized that rebuilding a province requires working on several fronts at once, and he structured his career accordingly.

Values and Leadership Philosophy

Those who work alongside Engr. Lao consistently point to three qualities that define how he operates: simplicity, patience, and compassion.

His reputation for simplicity comes from his insistence on clarity. He doesn't rely on technical jargon to create distance between himself and the communities he serves. When explaining complex infrastructure problems, whether to a boardroom of officials or a room full of cooperative members, he finds ways to make the issues accessible and actionable. It's a quality that has made him effective as a public communicator and as a leader.

His patience is especially significant given the context in which he works. Lanao del Sur has experienced decades of conflict, underdevelopment, and political instability. Quick fixes are tempting but usually ineffective in this environment. Engr. Lao has consistently advocated for long-term, phased approaches to infrastructure repair and development, prioritizing solutions that will hold up over time rather than ones that look good in the short term.

His compassion shows up in specific, practical ways. He is known for his sensitivity to the concerns of low-income consumers, particularly those who struggle with the cost of electricity, and he has used his platform at LASURECO to advocate for equitable billing and consumer protection. In a region where poverty remains widespread, that advocacy carries real weight.

Cultural Significance

In the Meranaw community, Engr. Lao occupies a role that goes beyond his job titles. He is often described as a modern "Engineer-Leader," a figure who carries the responsibilities of both technical expertise and communal stewardship.

This matters because, for the Meranaw people, the stability of infrastructure is inseparable from the survival of culture. Reliable electricity powers the workshops, markets, and schools where Meranaw artisans, traders, and students carry their heritage forward. Functional roads connect the communities where the traditions of *torogan* (royal house) culture, okir art, and kulintang music are kept alive. When Engr. Lao works to keep the lights on and the roads passable, he is, in a very real sense, working to keep the culture viable.

His work in the Marawi Rehabilitation Program adds another layer to this cultural role. The 2017 siege left the most historically rich area of the city in ruins. Rebuilding it isn't just an infrastructure project; it's a cultural reclamation effort. By participating in that reconstruction, Engr. Lao has tied his legacy to the return and revival of Meranaw civilization in its ancestral home.

Recognition

While formal awards and official recognition specific to Engr. Lao are not comprehensively documented in public records, his standing in the Bangsamoro engineering and cooperative sectors speaks for itself. His firm's selection as a major contractor for BARMM government infrastructure projects reflects the confidence that the regional government has placed in his work. His continued leadership at LASURECO, amid the formidable challenges facing the cooperative, reflects the trust of the members and the oversight bodies that he serves.

His organization of the 2025 Stakeholders Forum was itself a form of recognition by the sector that transparent, community-centered governance in the cooperative space is both necessary and possible.

Challenges and Obstacles

Engr. Lao has operated in one of the most challenging environments for infrastructure development in the Philippines. Lanao del Sur's geography, with its mountainous terrain, lake basin, and dispersed rural communities, presents formidable logistical obstacles for any construction or electrification effort.

Beyond geography, the region has had to contend with decades of armed conflict and political instability, both of which have disrupted infrastructure projects, frightened away investment, and drained public resources. The 2017 siege of Marawi was only the most dramatic of these disruptions; the underlying fragility of governance structures in the province has been a persistent challenge for anyone trying to build or repair public systems.

At LASURECO specifically, the cooperative has faced systemic issues including power supply shortfalls, aging infrastructure, and the cultural inertia of longstanding practices like the pakyaw system that took years of advocacy to reform. Managing a public utility under those conditions, while maintaining the trust of consumers who have every reason to be skeptical, requires a level of resilience and steady commitment that defines Engr. Lao's approach.

See Also

- Lanao del Sur Electric Cooperative (LASURECO)
- National Electrification Administration (https://nea.gov.ph) (NEA)
- Mindanao State University
- Marawi City
- Lanao del Sur
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Marawi Rehabilitation Program
- Lake Lanao
- Meranaw people

Further Reading

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